# Academic Capture

## China's Expanding Financial Footprint in U.S. Universities and the Transparency Gap

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## Executive Summary

Section 117 of the Higher Education Act requires U.S. universities that receive federal funds to disclose any foreign gifts or contracts valued at $250,000 or more in a calendar year. These disclosures are meant to provide transparency into foreign financial ties, but reporting practices vary widely, and descriptions of how funds are used are often missing.

China's financial ties to U.S. higher education are deepening rapidly, with Section 117 disclosures showing dramatic surges in gifts and contracts from 2022–2024. New York University alone reported nearly $200 million, including $80 million in 2024, while Stanford, Yale, and Duke each saw multi-hundred-percent year-over-year increases. Even regional institutions such as Rochester Institute of Technology ($30M in 2023) and Drake University ($12.6M in 2024) emerged as major recipients.

Yet the **transparency gap** is stark. The largest recipients — New York University (NYU), Stanford University, Yale University, Duke University, and University of California Davis, disclosed little to no information about how these funds were used. NYU reported only $360,000 of $198 million with descriptions, and Duke just $1.6 million of $37 million. In contrast, at Rochester Institute of Technology (RIT), Drake University, University of Michigan, Columbia University, and Brown University included detailed descriptions, covering endowed professorships, scholarships, medical partnerships, and China-focused academic programs. University of Michigan, for example, disclosed $8.2 million of its $9.8 million (83%) with descriptions.

This imbalance underscores a systemic weakness in Section 117: while the law requires reporting of foreign funds, it does not compel universities to specify their use. Only about 13% of Chinese-related reports include descriptions, leaving the overwhelming majority opaque. **The correlation is clear: the largest inflows are the least transparent, while the limited visibility we have comes from universities with smaller totals.**

Without stronger disclosure requirements, policymakers and the public are "flying blind" — able to see the scale of Chinese money but not its influence. The selective transparency skews the narrative, risks masking strategic vulnerabilities, and undermines accountability at precisely the universities where Chinese funding is most concentrated. This analysis demonstrates that Section 117, as currently structured, provides only a partial picture of foreign influence in U.S. higher education. Without reforms requiring donor-level identification, detailed descriptions of funding purposes, and independent verification of reports, the U.S. will remain vulnerable to hidden channels of influence that can shape research priorities, talent pipelines, and institutional governance in ways that serve Beijing's strategic interests rather than American.

## Methodology and Data Sources

This analysis draws on disclosures filed under **Section 117 of the Higher Education Act of 1965 (HEA)**. Section 117 requires U.S. universities that receive federal funding to report semiannually to the Department of Education any foreign gifts or contracts valued at $250,000 or more in a calendar year. These reports are publicly available through the Department of Education's Section 117 portal: https://fsapartners.ed.gov/knowledge-center/topics/section-117-foreign-gift-and-contract-reporting.

The timeframe for this study is **2022–2024**, focusing on new reported gifts and contracts attributed to sources in the People's Republic of China. This period covers the most recent three years of complete Section 117 data at the time of analysis.[1] Within these reports, institutions have the option of providing a **"Restricted Transaction Description"** to specify the intended purpose of the funding. When included, this field sheds light on whether a foreign gift or contract was earmarked for professorships, scholarships, joint institutes, medical programs, or other targeted uses. However, reporting practices are inconsistent. In the China-related dataset analyzed here, only about **13% of records include a description**, while nearly 87% list only the donor, recipient, amount, and date.

As a result, this study distinguishes between **described funding** (where intended uses are visible) and **undescribed funding** (where dollar inflows are opaque). This distinction is critical to assessing transparency and identifying gaps in the current reporting system.

### Limitations

The Section 117 dataset is **self-reported by universities**. The Department of Education collects these filings but does not independently audit or verify their accuracy, completeness, or consistency. As a result:

- Reported amounts may understate or omit certain foreign financial flows.
- Descriptions, when provided, reflect only what institutions chose to disclose and may be incomplete or vague.
- The absence of descriptions does not necessarily mean funds were unrestricted, only that no detail was provided.

1 *See* Section 117 Foreign Gift and Contract Reporting, U.S. Department of Education, Knowledge Center. Available at: https://fsapartners.ed.gov/knowledge-center/topics/section-117-foreign-gift-and-contract-reporting, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

These limitations mean the findings should be interpreted as a **baseline indicator of foreign financial entanglement**, not a comprehensive or fully transparent accounting of how Chinese funding is used within U.S. higher education.

## China's Funding Surge in U.S. Universities: Big Dollars, Minimal Transparency

Newly released Section 117 disclosures show New York University (NYU) reporting nearly $200 million in new Chinese gifts and contracts between 2022–2024, including $80 million in 2024 alone. Stanford University's intake jumped more than threefold over the same period, topping $32 million in 2024, while Harvard University, Columbia University, Duke University, and Yale University each disclosed tens of millions of dollars in Chinese support. Even schools outside the Ivy League, such as Rochester Institute of Technology (RIT), surfaced with a sudden $30 million influx in 2023.

**New York University (Total $198M) Disclosed 0.18%**
NYU stands out as the single largest recipient of Chinese gifts and contracts under Section 117 disclosures. The university reported **$53.1 million in 2022**, rising to **$64.5 million in 2023**, and then **jumping again to $80.4 million in 2024**. That marks a nearly **51% increase in just two years** and brings the total to **$198 million** over the 2022–2024 period. **NYU disclosed descriptions of only $360,000 in this time frame.**

**Stanford University (Total $50M) Disclosed 11%**
Stanford's reported Chinese funding climbed from **$8.9M in 2022** to **$9.1M in 2023**, before leaping to **$32M in 2024** — a **251% year-over-year surge**. That threefold increase in a single year underscore how quickly ties can expand, even at elite research institutions. **Stanford disclosed descriptions of only $5.9M in this time frame.**

**Yale University (Total $35M) Disclosed 28%**
Yale went from a modest **$3M in 2022** to **$7.1M in 2023**, then soared to **$23.8M in 2024** — a **236% increase in just one year**. It's one of the sharpest escalations among Ivy League schools. **Yale disclosed descriptions of only $9.8M in this time frame.**

**Duke University (Total $37M) Disclosed 4%**
After dipping to **$4.9M in 2023**, Duke exploded to **$19.4M in 2024** — nearly a **296% increase** year-over-year, one of the steepest jumps of any major U.S. university. **Duke disclosed descriptions of only $1.6M in this time frame.**

**Brown University (Total $16M) Disclosed 61%**
Brown saw a similar trajectory: **$2.7M in 2023** to **$10.9M in 2024**, a **294% surge**. For a mid-

sized Ivy, that sudden spike is particularly striking. **Brown disclosed descriptions of $9.9M in this time frame.**

**Rochester Institute of Technology (Total $30M) Disclosed 100%**
RIT didn't report any Chinese gifts in 2022 but then disclosed a sudden **$30M influx in 2023** — catapulting it into the top 10 overall, despite having no prior track record in the rankings. **RIT disclosed descriptions of $30M in this time frame.**

**Drake University (Total $12.5M) Disclosed 100%**
Similarly, Drake reported no Chinese funding in 2022 or 2023, but logged a sudden **$12.6M in 2024**. For a smaller, regional university, that's a dramatic entry point. **Drake disclosed descriptions of $12.5M in this time frame.**

**University of California, Davis (Total $7.4M) Disclosed 0%**
UC Davis jumped from **$1.3M in 2023** to **$6.1M in 2024**, a **380% increase**. While smaller in total dollars than NYU or Stanford, the relative growth rate is the largest in the dataset. **Davis did not disclose any descriptions of its gifts in this time frame.**

Here are some of the **biggest year-over-year jumps (2023 → 2024)** among the top 26 schools receiving gifts from China:

- **UC Davis**: from **$1.3M** to **$6.1M** — a **380% increase**
- **Duke University**: from **$4.9M** to **$19.4M** — nearly a **296% increase**
- **Brown University**: from **$2.7M** to **$10.9M** — a **294% increase**
- **Stanford University**: from **$9.1M** to **$32.1M** — a **251% increase**
- **Yale University**: from **$7.1M** to **$23.8M** — a **236% increase**

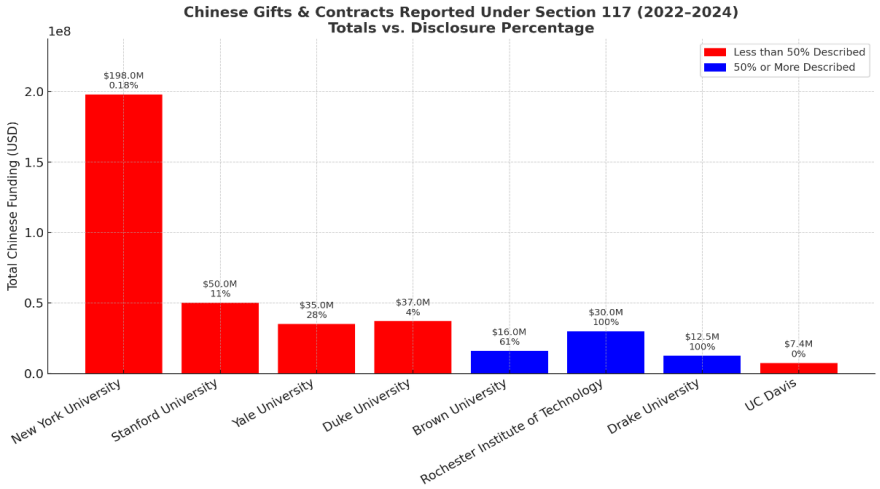


*Figure 1 China's Funding Surge in U.S. Universities 2022-2024 Totals vs. Disclosure Percentage*
***Red bars** = Chinese funding with less than 50% described* ***Blue bars** = Chinese funding with 50% or more described*

**Key takeaways:**

- NYU dominates with $198M, but only $360K is described.
- Stanford described just $5.9M out of $50M.
- Yale described just $9.8M out of $35M.
- Duke described just $1.6M out of $37M.
- UC Davis described zero out of $7.4M.
- Brown is the exception, with $9.9M out of $16M described.
- RIT and Drake described the full amounts.

In sum, the data reveal a widening disconnect between the **scale of Chinese funding** flowing into U.S. universities and the **transparency of how those dollars are used**. The largest recipients — led by NYU, Stanford, Yale, Duke, UC Davis, RIT, and Drake — together absorbed hundreds of millions of dollars between 2022–2024, yet for some disclosed little to nothing about what those funds supported.

## The Transparency Gap in Section 117 Disclosures

Out of the full Section 117 public reporting dataset, the ability to connect Chinese gifts to specific uses is extremely limited. Only 889 of 6,818 reports (≈ 13%) include a "Restricted Transaction Description", while nearly 87% lack any such detail.

That means correlations between foreign funds and their intended purposes can only be drawn in a handful of cases. The majority of reported Chinese gifts and contracts are therefore opaque, leaving most of the financial flows essentially non-transparent in terms of how they were directed inside U.S. universities.

Below are an assessment of those reports between 2022–2024:

**University of Michigan ($8.2M of $9.8M Total with Descriptions) – 83% Described**

- **Joint medical education programs** with Chinese institutions:
    - **Xiangya School of Medicine (Central South University)** – MD/PhD dual-degree program support (PhD in Michigan, MD in China)
    - **Peking University Health Science Center** – Joint Institute Impact Scholarship Program (collaborative medical education, research, patient care)
    - **Shanghai Jiao Tong University (SJTU)** – Support fund (Jane Sun & John Wu UM-SJTU Support Fund)

- Funding covers **tuition, stipends, and administrative fees** for Chinese medical students training at Michigan.

- "Specific faculty member named as Principal Investigator and responsibilities described in proposed research being funded by sponsor."

Michigan's restricted gifts are **tightly focused on joint medical education partnerships** with major Chinese universities.

**Columbia University ($31.5M of $43M Total with Descriptions) – 73% Described**

- **Endowments & Capital funds** (research, professorships, junior faculty chairs, operations)
- **Professorships** (including endowed chairs)
- **Fellowships & Scholarships** (student and faculty support)
- **General operations** and facilities support

Columbia's gifts are **broad-based**, covering nearly every category: research, teaching chairs, scholarships, operations, and infrastructure.

**Brown University ($9.6M of $16M Total with Descriptions) - 60% Described**

- **Professorships** with preferences for:
    - **China Studies**
    - **Macroeconomics**
    - **Diabetes and medical research** (Warren Alpert Medical School)
- **Scholarships** with preference for **international/Chinese students**

Brown's gifts are heavily **faculty-focused**, with explicit preferences tied to **China Studies** and **international student scholarships**.

**Massachusetts Institute of Technology ($9M of $17M Total with Descriptions) – 52% Described**

- **School of Engineering professorships**
- **3 full professorships + 1 career development chair (junior faculty)**
- MIT's restricted gifts are highly **targeted at engineering faculty endowments**.

**University of Pennsylvania ($9.7M of $24M Total with Descriptions) - $40% Described**

- **Wharton School / Analytics at Wharton Program**
- Funds support **teaching, research, and industry engagement initiatives using data for decision-making**

- **Faculty support** for innovative/creative research

Penn's restricted gifts are **concentrated on Wharton**, especially its analytics and data-driven decision-making initiatives.

**Harvard University ($4.6M of $44M Total with Descriptions) – 10% Described**

- **Professorship endowments**
- **Financial aid** with preference to **students from China, Asia, or Australia**
- **China-focused programs**:
    - Harvard China Engagement Endowment Fund
    - **China Conservation Collaboration at Arnold Arboretum** (protecting tree species)
- **Research support** tied to China engagement

Harvard's gifts cluster around **China-linked academic engagement, environmental programs, and scholarships**.

**University of Chicago ($4.2M of $35M Total with Descriptions) – 12% Described**

- **Scholarship funds** specifically for **students from China** (multiple separate entries, repetitive)
- Chicago's restricted Chinese gifts are **entirely scholarship-driven**, with direct geographic preference for **Chinese students**.

In sum, Section 117 disclosures provide only a narrow window into how Chinese funds are being directed inside U.S. universities. With nearly 87% of reported gifts and contracts lacking any description, the vast majority of financial flows remain opaque. The limited subset of reports that do include descriptions shows a consistent pattern: gifts tied to **endowed professorships, scholarships, joint medical education programs, and China-focused initiatives**. Columbia's funding spans nearly every category, Penn's concentrates on Wharton analytics, Brown's emphasizes China Studies and scholarships, MIT's targets engineering faculty, Harvard's supports China-linked academic and environmental programs, Chicago's focuses on Chinese student scholarships, and Michigan's centers on joint medical education with Chinese universities. While these examples highlight the kinds of activities Chinese donors prioritize, they represent only a fraction of the total flows — underscoring a systemic transparency gap in Section 117 reporting.

## Transparency Inversely Correlated with Scale

The data reveals a sharp imbalance, the largest inflows of Chinese funding to institutions like NYU ($198M), Stanford ($50M), Yale ($35M), Duke ($37M), and UC Davis ($7.4M) — provided only 0–11% descriptions, while smaller totals at Brown (60%), Columbia (73%), MIT (52%), and Michigan (83%) were far more transparent. Outliers such as RIT ($30M) and Drake ($12.5M) disclosed 100%. This inverse correlation shows that the universities taking in the largest sums are often the least transparent about how those funds are used, a gap that can mask major strategic risks such as influence over programs, faculty chairs, or joint institutes — while policymakers and the public see only raw dollar amounts.

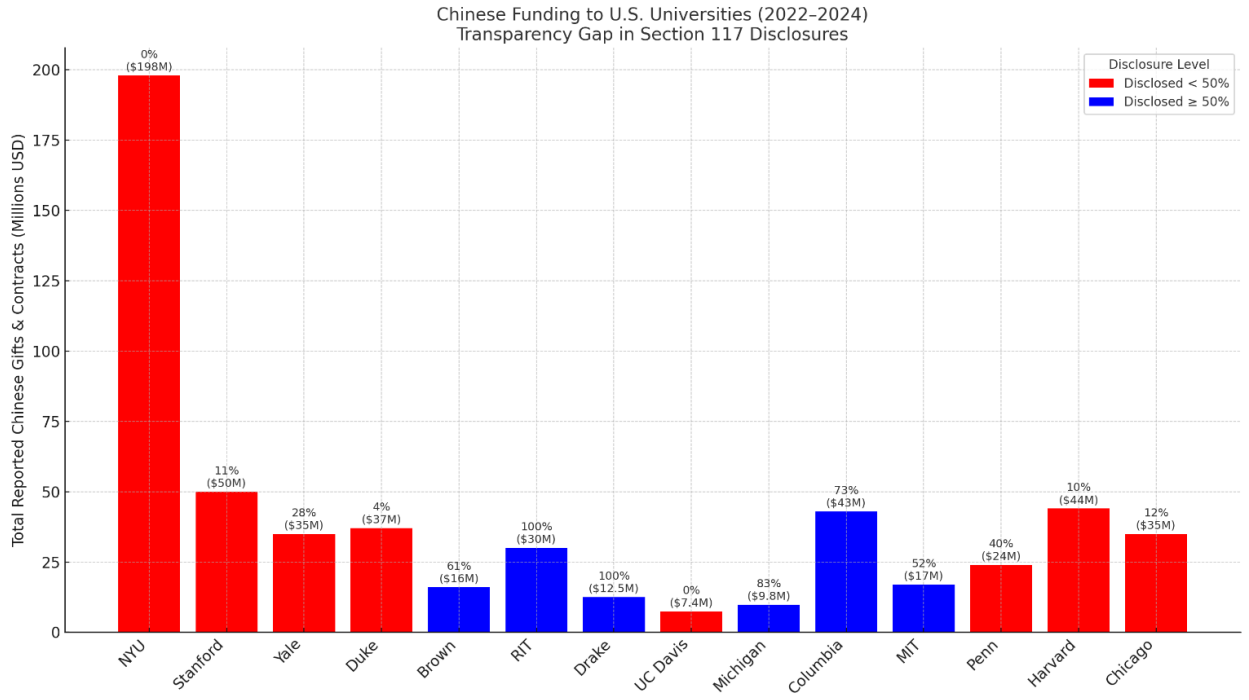


*Figure 2 Described vs. Undescribed Chinese Funding by University*

***Red bars** = Chinese funding with less than 50% described* ***Blue bars** = Chinese funding with 50% or more described*

**Key takeaways:**

- **Scale vs. Transparency:** The largest recipients of Chinese funding — NYU ($198M), Stanford ($50M), Yale ($35M), and Duke ($37M) — disclose little to nothing (0–11%).

- **Selective Transparency:** Smaller totals at Brown (60%), Columbia (73%), MIT (52%), and Michigan (83%) are far more detailed.

- **Outliers in Full Disclosure:** Rochester Institute of Technology ($30M) and Drake University ($12.5M) reported 100% of their inflows with descriptions.

- **Systemic Imbalance:** Transparency is inversely related to scale, masking potential strategic risks at the institutions receiving the most money.

In sum, the chart underscores that the largest inflows are the least transparent, while smaller totals reveal more detail — a systemic gap in Section 117 reporting.

## Red Flags in Reported Gifts

The following red flag examples underscore the risks hidden in plain sight — and they were uncovered using only roughly 13% of Section 117 reports that included descriptions, suggesting far more may be concealed within the 87% of opaque disclosures. These are just a sample of highlighted red flags:

At **Stanford** three recent line items raise concern: **"Custom/executive education program: participants are selected by the contract party."** With participants chosen not by Stanford but by the foreign funder, such programs could amount to specialized training pipelines for Chinese Communist Party (CCP)-affiliated officials or enterprise managers. Stanford has disclosed descriptions only six times overall, making these rare entries especially noteworthy in highlighting how Chinese gifts may be used for direct talent development rather than traditional academic purposes.

A **$10 million** restricted contract between **Texas A&M University (TAMU)** and the **Qingdao National Laboratory for Marine Science and Technology (青岛海洋科学与技术试点国家实验室)[2] (QNLM),** now shut down over national security concerns, illustrates the scale and depth of U.S.–China research collaborations captured in Section 117 disclosures.[3] Signed in 2018, the agreement created the International Laboratory for High-Resolution Earth System Prediction (iHESP) at TAMU, designed to advance cutting-edge modeling of Earth's climate and oceans. The partnership committed $2 million annually from QNLM, matched by TAMU through in-kind and financial support, to fund senior faculty, research staff, and joint deliverables such as high-resolution Community Earth System Model (CESM) simulations, data assimilation technologies, and ocean model development. While structured as a scientific collaboration with openly published outputs, the arrangement institutionalized recurring personnel exchanges and

2 *See* http://qnlm.ac/page?a=1&b=1&p=detail, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
3 *See* https://insideclimatenews.org/news/07042022/china-texas-am-climate-model-marco-rubio/, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

financial support for TAMU researchers directly from a Chinese state-backed laboratory. Crucially, QNLM is not simply a neutral marine science center — it operates under Beijing's strategic science initiatives and has established partnerships with the People's Liberation Army (PLA), making this agreement an example of how U.S. taxpayer-supported universities can be drawn into cooperative frameworks that overlap with China's defense-linked research ecosystem. A publication titled "Path Planning Rapid Algorithm Based on Modified RRT* for Unmanned Surface Vessel" reveals direct dual affiliations, with authors simultaneously listing the PLA Naval Submarine Academy and the Qingdao National Laboratory for Marine Science and Technology— underscoring how QNLM serves as a platform where military personnel actively conduct and publish research alongside QNLM.[4] Other publications show iHESP researchers collaborating with the National University of Defense Technology (NUDT), directly affiliated with the Central Military Commission.[5] [6]

*Figure 3 Wu Lixin, chairman of the Directors' Committee of the National Marine Pilot Laboratory and academician of the Chinese Academy of Sciences, Mark Barto, vice president of Texas A&M University and member of the National Academy of Engineering, Jean-François Lamarck, director of the Climate and Global Dynamics Laboratory of the National Center for Atmospheric Research, and Debbie Thomas, dean of the College of Geosciences at Texas A&M University, attended the opening ceremony and delivered speeches.*

Between 2017 and 2024, the QNLM formally partnered with the PLA Navy Submarine Academy and other defense-linked organizations to establish a series of joint military-civil fusion laboratories. Such as the Marine Military-Civil Fusion Joint Laboratory (海洋军民融合联合实验室) partnered with the PLA's Naval Submarine Academy. These labs were created to combine cutting-edge ocean research with naval operational needs, focusing on fields such as advanced ocean sensing, navigation technology, and deep-sea exploration. Official announcements describe them as 联合实验室 (joint laboratories), 创新基地 (innovation bases),

4 *See* https://www.china-simulation.com/CN/10.16182/j.issn1004731x.joss.22-1381, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
5 *See* https://journals.ametsoc.org/view/journals/mwre/148/6/mwrD190304.xml, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
6 *See* https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/9186649/authors#authors, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

and 教学实践基地 (training bases), where dual affiliated QNLM-PLA scientists and naval officers collaborate on both R&D and talent training.[7] [8] [9] [10]

Da Lianglong (笪良龙)[11] is a major general who serves as a director at the PLA's Naval Submarine Academy and leads the Joint Laboratory of Marine Application Technology (海洋应用技术联合实验室) at the QNLM. Over three decades, he has advanced China's research on the marine acoustic environment, developing technologies that improve submarine stealth—likened to providing an "invisibility cloak" for undersea operations. His work has significantly elevated China's capabilities in submarine warfare, unmanned detection, and undersea environmental monitoring.[12]

*Figure 4 PLA Navy Major General Da Lianglong*

Other QNLM joint labs include the Joint Laboratory for Marine High-end Equipment (海洋高端装备联合实验室)[13], created with China Shipbuilding Industry Corporation, focuses on developing advanced ships, submarines, and high-performance marine sensors to directly support China's naval equipment programs. Meanwhile, the Joint Laboratory for Ocean Observation and Exploration (海洋观测与探测联合实验室), built with Tianjin University, develops ocean sensing and detection technologies that integrate space and sea systems, serving both scientific research and potential naval ISR applications. The Joint Laboratory has developed the underwater gliders "Haiyan-L", "Haiyan-X Plus", "Haiyan-4000", "Floating Star" and others.[14] This case highlights how a seemingly scientific collaboration like iHESP was embedded within QNLM's broader network of dual-use and defense-linked labs, showing that U.S. funding and personnel exchanges with QNLM effectively intersected with China's military-civil fusion system and directly bolstered the PLA's undersea warfare capabilities.

7 *See* https://www.qtxy.mil.cn/xyjj/2020-05-12/2.html, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
8 *See* https://www.deepinfar.com/cn/news/view/id/37.html, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
9 *See* https://www.taibo.cn/p/56329, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
10 *See* https://zhxy.nwsuaf.edu.cn/xsgz/jyxx/29360e79b553436ea30bbd79adf06a01.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
11 *See* https://news.ouc.edu.cn/2023/1123/c482a114738/page.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
12 *See* https://dzrb.dzng.com/articleContent/17_1028180.html, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
13 *See* https://www.most.gov.cn/dfkj/sd/zxdt/201703/t20170302_131578.html, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
14 *See* https://www.sohu.com/a/369326344_726570, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

At **MIT**, a $28M contract from the period of January 2016 to January 2026 from the Ningbo Municipal Government for ”funds used to establish a new research center" likely relates to the establishment of Ningbo China Institute for Supply Chain Innovation (NISCI). In 2016 the government of Ningbo, China, signed a strategic cooperation agreement with the MIT to jointly establish NISCI.[15] In 2016 it was reported that under the guidance of the MIT Center for Transportation and Logistics and 宁波(中国)供应链创新学院 (NISCI)[16], the cooperation will strive to become China's top international professional college with global influence after 10 years of construction, actively serve the country's "Belt and Road" and Yangtze River Economic Belt construction, help Ningbo build a "Belt and Road" strategic fulcrum city, and build an "one circle and three centers" with international influence.[17] This $28M MIT–Ningbo contract illustrates a major red flag: U.S. research partnerships are being directly leveraged to build institutions like NISCI that explicitly serve Beijing’s Belt and Road and military-civil fusion strategies, and since at least 2019 it has likely funneled MIT’s expertise, faculty exchanges, and student training into a platform advancing China’s strategic supply chain dominance under this framework.[18] [19]

*Figure 5 NSCIIC grand opening, 2019, MIT Center for Transportation and Logistics Director Professor Yossi Sheffi welcomed Suzanne Glassburn, vice president and secretary of the MIT Corporation; Guo; Ningbo Deputy Mayor Yanan Xu; and other notable guests*

At **NYU**, 15 described cases include agreements such as financial support for faculty research projects funded by the **Shanghai Municipal Education Commission** and an unusual entry labeled **“Gender Restriction”** ($360,000), concerning because such a restriction could allow a foreign donor to dictate access to U.S. university resources based on gender, potentially only for Chinese nationals. This raises issues of donor influence, equity, and alignment with American norms and laws. While NYU is the single largest recipient of Chinese funding overall, these sparse descriptions underscore how little visibility exists into the nature or conditions of most of its reported inflows.

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15 *See* https://scale.mit.edu/centers/ningbo-china-institute-supply-chain-innovation, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
16 *See* https://www.nisci.edu.cn/, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
17 *See* https://www.chinanews.com/df/2016/02-16/7759908.shtml, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
18 *See* https://www.nisci.edu.cn/news202384.html, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
19 *See* https://news.mit.edu/2019/mit-expands-global-supply-chain-research-new-facilities-ningbo-china-1018, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

The **Rochester Institute of Technology** has reported roughly **$108.1** million in restricted contracts with **Beijing Jiaotong University (BJTU) since 2014**. These agreements cover a series of joint bachelor's and master's degree programs in management information systems, entrepreneurship, and technology innovation, with detailed provisions on faculty qualifications, student admissions, and degree issuance. This makes RIT one of the most deeply embedded U.S. universities in long-term, large-scale academic collaborations with a Chinese partner institution.[20] BJTU is jointly overseen by the Ministry of Education, the Ministry of Transport, the Beijing Municipal Government, and China State Railway Group Co., Ltd.[21] BJTU has formalized multiple military-civil fusion partnerships, including a 2017 seminar with the National Transportation War Readiness Office and a 2018 strategic cooperation agreement with the Army Military Transportation Academy to jointly research defense transportation, logistics, and establish a dedicated research center. That same year, BJTU partnered with the 302 Institute of CASIC's Third Academy on UAV R&D and has also collaborated with military-civil fusion enterprise Beijing Civil United Airlines to train personnel.[22] RIT's joint programs in management information systems with BJTU could directly strengthen the PLA's capacity to integrate logistics, transportation, and command systems into military-civil fusion frameworks, enhancing efficiency and decision-making in defense operations.

In a rare level of detail, **Bryant University** reported over **$40.5 million** since 2015 tied to its jointly operated institute with **Beijing Institute of Technology, Zhuhai (BITZH)**. One 2024 entry notes a **50-year memorandum of understanding**, with BITZH reimbursing Bryant for program expenses. This stands out as one of the few cases where Section 117 disclosures clearly link a U.S. university to a long-term, formalized academic partnership with a major Chinese defense-linked institution. **BITZH** is run by **Beijing Institute of Technology (BIT)**, a "Seven Sons of National Defense" institution. The BITZH website states that BIT "has forged a "Red Education Path" of higher education with Chinese characteristics, founded and led by the Communist Party of China; a "Strengthening the Army and Serving the Country Path" based on its traditional advantages in national defense and serving national

中华人民共和国驻纽约总领事馆
Consulate General of the People's Republic of China in New York

**Congratulation Letter**

September 29, 2015

On behalf of the Chinese Consulate General in New York, I would like to express my warmest congratulations to Bryant University (Bryant) and Beijing Institute of Technology, Zhuhai (BITZH) for the opening of this US-China joint program.

I am happy to note that for the past decade, Bryant University has made China its primary focus for international education exchanges. And Bryant University under the leadership of President Ronald Machtley has become a leading institution that has a variety of innovative exchange programs with China. I truly believe that the joint program between Bryant and BITZH will help further promote the mutual understanding between our two peoples and thus contribute to our most important bilateral relations between two great nations.

I wish this joint program much success.

Sincerely yours,

Zhang Qiyue
Consul General of the People's Republic of China in New York

*Figure 6 Congratulation Letter from the PRC Consulate in New York*

20 *See* https://www.rit.edu/news/rit-expands-partnership-beijing-university, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
21 *See* https://en.bjtu.edu.cn/AboutBJTU/index.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
22 *See* https://web.archive.org/web/20240313224904/https://unitracker.aspi.org.au/universities/beijing-jiaotong-university, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

strategies; and a "Path of Innovative Development" characterized by openness, inclusiveness, integration, and collaboration."[23] The BITZH school introduction website page states "we cultivate high-end talents who absorb the essence of Eastern and Western education, have a global vision, international competitiveness, are familiar with international economic operation models, grasp the latest trends in modern science and technology, are deeply familiar with Chinese culture and understand China's national conditions, have the characteristics of global localization (Glocal = Global + Local), can adapt to the future development of the world and China, have international and cross-cultural communication skills, international competitiveness and innovative spirit, and are compound high-end talents who will contribute to China's modernization drive."[24] This makes clear that Bryant's long-term partnership is not just academic, but directly embedded in Beijing Institute of Technology's defense-linked mission and ideological training goals. The Bryant University–Zhuhai joint institute openly embeds CCP ideological training into its operations. In 2024, its Party branch launched a "secretary project" that provided staff training on translating Xi Jinping's quotes, business etiquette, and foreign affairs protocol — explicitly linking Party building with the administration of the Sino-foreign cooperative program.[25] The Bryant–Zhuhai Party branch held a 2023 general meeting that combined strict Party governance with ideological indoctrination and membership expansion. The session featured bilingual study of Xi Jinping's directives on "self-revolution," the admission and promotion of new Party members through secret ballots, and thematic education designed to "tell the story of the Party well" while embedding CCP political narratives into a Sino-foreign educational setting.[26]

Another notable case is a **$500,000** Chinese gift to **Boston University** reported in the Section 117 data. The description states it was "to provide support for the new IDG Capital Student Innovation Center as part of the Innovate@BU Initiative." Public BU sources confirm the **BUild Lab IDG Capital Student Innovation Center** was named in recognition of lead support from IDG Capital and its CEO Hugo Shong, a BU trustee with deep ties to China.[27] [28] This highlights how foreign gifts can shape university infrastructure and branding, embedding donor influence in prominent campus hubs meant to engage students and connect with the broader entrepreneurial ecosystem. IDG Capital has been a major Chinese venture firm with early stakes in companies now sanctioned for supporting the PLA, including **SenseTime, Megvii, and Qihoo 360**. Its role in cultivating these firms underscores how venture capital has helped build

23 *See* https://www.bitzh.edu.cn/index/#/historyDetail, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
24 *See* https://bryant.bitzh.edu.cn/xmgk/xmjj.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
25 *See* https://bryant.bitzh.edu.cn/info/1058/6073.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
26 *See* https://bryant.bitzh.edu.cn/info/1058/5673.htm, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
27 *See* https://www.bu.edu/articles/2019/campaign-for-boston-university-faq/, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
28 *See* https://www.bu.edu/innovate/about/student-innovation-center/, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

China's defense-linked technology ecosystem while simultaneously branding itself through high-profile gifts at U.S. universities.[29] [30]

The **China Scholarship Council (CSC)** is one of the PRC's most important tools for funding, controlling, and monitoring Chinese students and researchers abroad, yet its footprint in U.S. Section 117 disclosures appears artificially small. The data show just a handful of reported transactions — a $300,000 contract with the **University of Maryland**, a $250,000 arrangement with **Illinois Institute of Technology**, scattered six-figure gifts to **Princeton**, and a series of tuition payments at **Columbia** totaling less than $200,000. Altogether, this amounts to only a few million dollars across four universities over several years. Given CSC's scale supporting **tens of thousands of scholars worldwide every year** and its contractual requirements for loyalty pledges, political reporting, and service obligations, this low visibility is almost certainly an artifact of **underreporting** rather than an accurate reflection of CSC's role. Most CSC-funded students and visiting researchers at U.S. institutions are not captured in Section 117 filings, either because their tuition is routed indirectly, their support is classified as stipends instead of gifts/contracts, or universities fail to report these flows altogether. This gap leaves policymakers blind to one of Beijing's most pervasive mechanisms for shaping academic pipelines, cultivating influence, and embedding CCP oversight into U.S. higher education.[31] [32]

## Policy Recommendations: Closing the Transparency Gap in Section 117

The analysis of Section 117 disclosures reveals a fundamental imbalance: the universities receiving the largest inflows of Chinese gifts and contracts provide the least transparency about how those funds are used, while a smaller set of institutions with modest totals report more detailed descriptions. This selective transparency undermines accountability and masks potential risks of foreign influence over U.S. higher education.

Congressional oversight and legislative action will be essential. The House Committee on Education and the Workforce and the Senate HELP Committee — as the primary bodies responsible for the Higher Education Act — should lead in updating Section 117. Additional coordination with the House Science, Space, and Technology Committee, the Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee, and the Armed Services Committees is needed to ensure research security concerns are addressed. Oversight Committees — the House Oversight and Accountability Committee and the Senate Homeland Security and

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29 *See* https://www.sensetime.com/en/news-detail/4004?categoryId=1072, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
30 *See* https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2024-02-06/idg-capital-works-to-rebut-us-claims-over-china-military-ties, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
31 *See* https://selectcommitteeontheccp.house.gov/media/press-releases/ccp-on-campus-moolenaar-demands-universities-end-joint-programs-tied-to-chinese-tech-theft, last accessed Sept 24, 2025
32 *See* https://www.dataabyss.ai/reports/weaponized-education, last accessed Sept 24, 2025

Governmental Affairs Committee — should be empowered to audit compliance and enforce penalties where foreign influence risks are concealed.

1. **Mandatory Transparency for Adversary Countries**

    - Require universities that receive federal funding to provide detailed reporting on any gifts or contracts, at a minimum, originating from countries of concern (e.g., China, Russia, Iran).
    - These disclosures should not be optional; they must be standardized, audited, and made publicly available.

2. **Disclosure of Donors Beyond Country-Level**

    - Universities should be required to name the specific **individuals, corporations, and organizations** behind foreign gifts or contracts — not just the country of origin.
    - This donor-level transparency is essential to track whether gifts are tied to state-directed enterprises, military-linked institutions, or politically influential actors.

3. **Granular Descriptions of Funding Use**

    - Current descriptions like *"research support," "professorship endowments,"* or *"three full professorships"* are insufficient.
    - Institutions should be mandated to specify the e**xact purpose, program, faculty role, and conditions** attached to foreign gifts, including whether funds are tied to dual-use research, talent pipelines, or ideological programs.

4. **Independent Oversight and Verification**

    - The Department of Education should establish an independent office (or partner with existing inspector general authorities) to verify Section 117 disclosures, ensuring accuracy and completeness.
    - Penalties for incomplete or misleading disclosures should be introduced, including potential suspension of eligibility for federal research funding.

5. **Risk-Based Reporting Requirements**

    - For gifts/contracts tied to institutions or companies identified as supporting adversary governments' military or political agendas, universities should be required to submit **enhanced due diligence reports.**

- These reports should assess potential risks of foreign influence on research, faculty recruitment, and campus governance.

6. **Linking Transparency to Federal Funding**

    - Federal funding for research should be contingent on universities demonstrating full Section 117 compliance.
    - Institutions that fail to provide transparent and descriptive disclosures should risk ineligibility for Department of Defense, NASA, NSF, or NIH research awards.

Section 117 in its current form leaves the largest flows of Chinese money into U.S. higher education opaque, with only about 13% of disclosures including descriptions. Unless Congress acts, universities will continue to accept hundreds of millions of dollars with little accountability. Updating the law through the House Committee on Education and the Workforce and the Senate HELP Committee — in coordination with the Science, Commerce, Armed Services, and Oversight Committees — is essential to close this gap. By mandating donor-level transparency, detailed purpose-specific reporting, and independent verification, Congress can ensure that U.S. taxpayer-funded universities are not vulnerable to hidden channels of foreign influence and that America's research enterprise remains secure, accountable, and aligned with national interests.